

win11-window-tiling User Manual

win11-window-tiling — User Manual

Version 1.0.0

Windows 11-style automatic window tiling for Debian and Debian-based desktops (GNOME, KDE Plasma, X11).

Table of Contents

- 1. [What This Package Does](#)
 - 2. [System Requirements](#)
 - 3. [Installation](#)
 - 4. [First-Time Setup](#)
 - 5. [Daily Use](#)
 - 6. [Configuration](#)
 - 7. [Command Reference](#)
 - 8. [Keyboard Shortcuts](#)
 - 9. [Troubleshooting](#)
 - 10. [Uninstalling](#)
 - 11. [File Locations](#)
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1. What This Package Does

win11-window-tiling brings Windows 11-style window management to Linux:

Feature	Description
Snap layouts	Tile windows to halves, quarters, and custom zones
Snap Assistant	Drag a window to the top of the screen to pick a layout (GNOME)
Edge snapping	Drag windows to screen edges to snap them (GNOME, KDE)
Keyboard shortcuts	Super + arrow keys, matching Windows 11
Auto-detection	Picks the best tiling backend for your desktop environment

The package does **not** replace your desktop environment. It installs and configures the right tiling tool for your session:

Desktop	Backend
GNOME (Debian 12+)	Tiling Shell extension

Desktop

Backend

KDE Plasma 6

KZones KWin script

X11 fallback (XFCE, MATE, Cinnamon, etc.) `wmctrl` + `xbindkeys`

2. System Requirements

Required (installed automatically with the package)

- `python3`
- `dbus` or `dbus-x11`
- `x11-utils`

Recommended (for full functionality)

Package	Used for
<code>wmctrl</code> , <code>xdotool</code> , <code>xbindkeys</code>	X11 fallback tiling
<code>gnome-extensions</code> or <code>gnome-shell-extension-prefs</code>	GNOME extension management
<code>plasma-workspace</code> , <code>kwin-x11</code> or <code>kwin-wayland</code>	KDE Plasma tiling

Supported desktops

- **GNOME 45+** (Debian 12 / 13 with modern GNOME Shell)
- **KDE Plasma 6**
- **XFCE, MATE, Cinnamon** and other X11 desktops (fallback mode)

Note: On Wayland sessions without GNOME or KDE, native tiling is limited. Install GNOME or KDE for the best experience.

3. Installation

Step 1 — Install the package

If you have the `.deb` file (e.g. in `~/Downloads`):

```
sudo dpkg -i ~/Downloads/win11-window-tiling_1.0.0_all.deb
```

Step 2 — Fix missing dependencies (if prompted)

```
sudo apt install -f
```

This installs recommended packages such as `wmctrl`, `xdotool`, and `xbindkeys`.

Step 3 — Verify installation

```
dpkg -l win11-window-tiling
```

You should see Status: install ok installed.

Step 4 — Run setup

```
win11-tiling-setup
```

Step 5 — Log out and back in

Tiling extensions and autostart entries need a fresh session to take effect.

4. First-Time Setup

The setup command detects your desktop and configures the appropriate backend.

```
win11-tiling-setup
```

Force a specific backend

Command	Use when
<code>win11-tiling-setup --gnome</code>	You use GNOME and want Tiling Shell
<code>win11-tiling-setup --kde</code>	You use KDE Plasma and want KZones
<code>win11-tiling-setup --x11</code>	You want the wmctrl/xbindkeys fallback

Check setup status

```
win11-tiling-setup --status
```

Example output on GNOME:

```
Detected desktop: gnome
Session type:    wayland
Setup status:    configured (2026-06-28T10:45:00-05:00
gnome)
GNOME extension: installed
```

What setup does (by desktop)

GNOME - Installs the Tiling Shell extension to `~/.local/share/gnome-shell/extensions/` - Enables the extension via `gnome-extensions` (if available) - Uses the modern or legacy extension build based on your GNOME Shell version

KDE Plasma - Copies the KZones KWin script to `~/.local/share/kwin/scripts/` - Loads and runs the script via KWin's scripting API - Configures Windows 11-style Super + arrow shortcuts in KGlobalAccel

X11 fallback - Copies hotkey config to ~/.config/win11-tiling/xbindkeysrc - Adds an autostart entry so xbindkeys starts on login - Starts xbindkeys immediately if it is installed

5. Daily Use

GNOME

After logging back in, confirm **Tiling Shell** is enabled:

1. Open **Extensions** (search “Extensions” in Activities, or run `gnome-extensions-app`)
2. Find **Tiling Shell** and ensure the toggle is **on**

Snap with the mouse

- **Drag a window to the top edge** — Snap Assistant appears with layout thumbnails (like Windows 11).
- **Drag to the left or right edge** — Snap to half-screen or quarters.
- **Hold Ctrl while dragging** — Use the tiling system to place the window in a specific tile.
- **Hold Alt while dragging** — Span the window across multiple tiles.

Snap with the keyboard

Focus a window, then press:

Shortcut	Action
Super + Left	Move to the tile on the left
Super + Right	Move to the tile on the right
Super + Up	Move to the tile above
Super + Down	Move to the tile below

Window menu

Right-click a window’s title bar. Tiling Shell adds **snap** and **auto-tile** options when `override-window-menu` is enabled (default).

Alt+Tab

Tiled windows can be grouped in the Alt+Tab switcher so you can raise all tiled windows together.

KDE Plasma

After setup and re-login:

Snap with the mouse

- **Drag windows to screen edges** — KZones snaps them into predefined zones.

Snap with the keyboard

Shortcut	Action
Super + Left	Tile to left half
Super + Right	Tile to right half
Super + Up	Maximize
Super + Down	Minimize
Super + Shift + Left	Top-left quarter
Super + Shift + Right	Top-right quarter
Super + Shift + Down	Bottom-left quarter
Super + Shift + Up	Bottom-right quarter

KZones settings

Open **System Settings** → **Window Management** → **KWin Scripts** to adjust zone layouts and behavior.

X11 (XFCE, MATE, Cinnamon, etc.)

Hotkeys are managed by xbindkeys and start automatically on login.

Shortcut	Action
Super + Left	Left half
Super + Right	Right half
Super + Up	Maximize
Super + Down	Restore (un-maximize and resize)
Super + Shift + Left	Top-left quarter
Super + Shift + Right	Top-right quarter
Super + Shift + Down	Bottom-left quarter
Super + Shift + Up	Bottom-right quarter

Manual tiling from the terminal

win11-tile left
win11-tile right
win11-tile top-left
win11-tile maximize
win11-tile restore
win11-tile center

6. Configuration

GNOME — Tiling Shell settings

Open **Extensions** → **Tiling Shell** → **gear icon** (or search “Tiling Shell” in Settings).

Recommended settings to explore

Setting	Default	What it does
Enable snap assist	On	Show layout picker when dragging to top edge
Enable tiling system	On	Hold Ctrl while moving to snap into tiles
Active screen edges	On	Resize/snapping when dragging to edges
Enable auto tiling	Off	Automatically tile new windows into the best tile
Inner gaps	16 px	Space between tiles
Outer gaps	8 px	Space between layout and monitor edge
Enable move keybindings	On	Super + arrow key tiling
Edge tiling mode	default	How edge snaps behave (default / adaptive / granular)

Custom layouts (Fancy Zones)

In Tiling Shell settings:

1. Open the **Layouts** section.
2. Create or import custom tile grids.
3. Assign layouts per monitor and per workspace.
4. Use **Cycle layouts** keybindings (assign in the Keybindings section).

Change keyboard shortcuts (GNOME)

In Tiling Shell settings → **Keybindings**:

- Move window left/right/up/down
- Span window across tiles
- Untile window
- Focus next/previous tiled window
- Cycle layouts

Defaults match Windows 11 (Super + arrows). Change any binding to your preference.

GNOME settings via command line

Example: disable snap assist

```
gsettings set org.gnome.shell.extensions.tilingshell enable-snap-assist false
```

Example: increase gap between tiles

```
gsettings set org.gnome.shell.extensions.tilingshell inner-gaps 24
```

KDE — KZones and shortcuts

Zone layouts: System Settings → Window Management → KWin Scripts → KZones

Keyboard shortcuts: System Settings → Shortcuts → KWin

The setup script pre-configures Meta (Super) + arrow shortcuts. Adjust them in KWin shortcut settings if they conflict with other bindings.

X11 — xbindkeys config

User config file:

```
~/.config/win11-tiling/xbindkeysrc
```

Edit this file to change hotkeys. Example entry:

```
"win11-tile left"  
Mod4 + Left
```

Mod4 is the Super/Windows key.

After editing, restart xbindkeys:

```
pkill xbindkeys  
xbindkeys -f ~/.config/win11-tiling/xbindkeysrc
```

Or log out and back in (autostart handles it).

7. Command Reference

Command	Description
win11-tiling-setup	Detect desktop and configure tiling
win11-tiling-setup --gnome	Force GNOME / Tiling Shell setup
win11-tiling-setup --kde	Force KDE / KZones setup

Command	Description
win11-tiling-setup --x11	Force X11 wmctrl + xbindkeys setup
win11-tiling-setup --status	Show current configuration status
win11-tiling-setup --uninstall	Remove user configuration
win11-tiling-setup --help	Show usage information
win11-tile <position>	Manually tile the active window (X11/KDE)

win11-tile positions

left, right, top, bottom
top-left, top-right, bottom-left, bottom-right
maximize (or up), restore (or down), center

On GNOME, use Tiling Shell shortcuts and drag-to-snap instead of win11-tile.

8. Keyboard Shortcuts

Quick reference (all desktops):

Shortcut	GNOME	KDE	X11
Super + Left	Move to left tile	Tile left half	Left half
Super + Right	Move to right tile	Tile right half	Right half
Super + Up	Move up / maximize	Maximize	Maximize
Super + Down	Move down / restore	Minimize	Restore
Super + Shift + arrows	(configure in extension)	Quarter tiles	Quarter tiles
Drag to top edge	Snap Assistant	—	—
Drag to side edges	Edge snap	KZones snap	—
Ctrl + drag (GNOME)	Tiling system	—	—
Alt + drag (GNOME)	Span multiple tiles	—	—

9. Troubleshooting

Setup says “not configured”

win11-tiling-setup

Then log out and back in.

GNOME: extension not working after setup

1. Check it is enabled:

```
gnome-extensions list --enabled | grep tilingshell
```

2. If missing, enable it:

```
gnome-extensions enable tilingshell@ferrarodomenico.com
```

3. Re-run setup:

```
win11-tiling-setup --gnome
```

4. **Log out and back in** (required after installing a GNOME Shell extension).

5. If the extension shows as “incompatible”, your GNOME Shell version may not be supported. Check:

```
gnome-shell --version
```

Tiling Shell in this package supports GNOME Shell 45–49.

GNOME: Super + arrow does nothing

- Another extension or GNOME setting may be using the same shortcuts.
 - Open **Tiling Shell** → **Keybindings** and verify bindings are set.
 - Confirm **Enable keybindings** is turned on.
 - Check for conflicts in **Settings** → **Keyboard** → **Keyboard Shortcuts**.
-

KDE: zones or shortcuts not working

1. Verify the script is installed:

```
ls ~/.local/share/kwin/scripts/kzones.kwinscript
```

2. Re-run setup:

```
win11-tiling-setup --kde
```

3. Restart KWin or log out and back in.

4. Check **System Settings** → **Shortcuts** for conflicting Meta bindings.

X11: hotkeys not working

1. Confirm dependencies:

```
sudo apt install wmctrl xdotool xbindkeys
```

2. Check xbindkeys is running:

```
pgrep -a xbindkeys
```

3. Start manually:

```
xbindkeys -f ~/.config/win11-tiling/xbindkeysrc
```

4. Test tiling directly:

```
win11-tile left
```

Wayland warning during setup

If you see:

WARNING: Wayland session without native GNOME/KDE support.

You are on a Wayland session that is not GNOME or KDE. The X11 fallback has limited Wayland support. Use GNOME or KDE for full tiling, or switch to an X11 session.

Package won't install

If `dpkg` reports a control file error, ensure you have the rebuilt package (fixed trailing newline in the control file). Re-download or rebuild, then:

```
sudo dpkg -i ~/Downloads/win11-window-tiling_1.0.0_all.deb
sudo apt install -f
```

10. Uninstalling

Remove user configuration only

```
win11-tiling-setup --uninstall
```

This removes: - `~/.config/win11-tiling/` - GNOME Tiling Shell extension (user copy) - KDE KZones script - X11 autostart entry - Running `xbindkeys` process

Log out and back in after uninstalling user config.

Remove the package entirely

```
win11-tiling-setup --uninstall
sudo apt remove win11-window-tiling
```

11. File Locations

Path	Purpose
/usr/bin/win11-tiling-setup	Main setup and status command
/usr/bin/win11-tile	Manual window tiling CLI
/usr/share/win11-tiling/	Bundled extensions, scripts, defaults
/usr/share/doc/win11-window-tiling/README	Short package readme
~/.config/win11-tiling/	User config (X11 xbindkeys, setup marker)
~/.config/win11-tiling/installed	Setup timestamp and desktop type
~/.config/autostart/win11-tiling-x11.desktop	X11 autostart entry
~/.local/share/gnome-shell/extensions/ tilingshell@ferrarodomenico.com/	GNOME extension (user install)
~/.local/share/kwin/scripts/kzones.kwinscript	KDE KZones script

Quick Start Checklist

- Install: `sudo dpkg -i win11-window-tiling_1.0.0_all.deb`
 - Fix deps: `sudo apt install -f`
 - Setup: `win11-tiling-setup`
 - Log out and back in
 - Verify: `win11-tiling-setup --status`
 - Enable extension (GNOME): Extensions app → Tiling Shell → ON
 - Test: Super + Left on a window, or drag a window to the top of the screen
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